

4 Ways to Get Your Kid to Like School

1 Run a dress rehearsal.

Research shows that gradual exposure to what we fear can help us overcome it, which can help when it comes to kids and school. Putting together a couple "dress rehearsals" for back-to-school might include practicing getting ready for school in the morning, driving by the school and practicing drop-off and pick-up, and spending some time outside the building while doing some deep breaths or positive affirmations.

"The key is for caregivers and children to do this together, so caregivers can model staying calm and give encouragement along the way," said Jessica Stern, Ph.D., a child psychologist at the University of Virginia. "The message kids most need to hear as they practice facing their back-to-school fears is: 'We're in this together, and I've got your back.'"



2 Use the right language.

Speaking with your child about the specific reasons they don't like school is important, but it's equally important to use the right words when doing so. "This may look like asking questions that affirm their feelings, such as, 'That must feel really scary. Can you tell me more about that?'" said Eileen Conroy, a former therapist and mental health expert with find-a-therapist.com.

You might also try paraphrasing what they said with statements like, "You must have felt really angry when your classmate stole your notebook and the teacher didn't notice." "Not only will this help your child feel understood, it may also help you gain some clarity into why they are struggling," Conroy added.

That must feel really scary.

Tell me more.



3 Bring in an element of play.

Another tactic Conroy is fond of — particularly for younger kids — is the magic wand technique. After your child has expressed their dislike of school, try asking them, "If you had a magic wand that would help going to school feel better, what would you do?" Their answer might reveal something simple — like a different morning routine — or something that requires a bit more digging, like issues with a friend or teacher, or traveling to and from school on the bus. However your child responds, use that to help figure out your next steps.



4 Create a 'conquer your fear' list.

Michelle Nielson, CEO of HiveWheel, an executive functioning company that coaches kindergarten through college students, suggests parents sit down with their kids and put together a list of things the kids fear about school, assigning each fear a number from one to five of how much they fear them. Then, create a list of things that would be exciting for the child to do or receive, and assign the fun things a number from one to five reflecting how excited they'd be to do or get them. When the child conquers a four or five fear, let them pick out a four or five reward to celebrate. Science shows that our brains release chemicals that help us remember and expect rewards, which makes us more likely to follow through on similar responses in the future.



Support
Encourage
Believe



Happy Kids
Build Brighter
Futures